> **NITISH KUMAR'S INTENT WASN'T HONEST. OURS IS AN IDEOLOGICAL ALLIANCE. IT'S NOT JUST TO GRAB POWER. IT'S HYPOCRISY TO TALK ABOUT SECULARISM AND THEN JOIN HANDS WITH THE BJP"**



> **WE ARE FIGHTING FOR A CAUSE, NOT AN INDIVIDUAL [KEJRIWAL]. INVESTIGATIONS SHOULD FOLLOW THE LAWS OF THE LAND. WE ARE FIGHTING AGAINST THE SYSTEMATIC DISMANTLING OF DEMOCRATIC NORMS BY THE MODI GOVT"**

Threatening contractors. Sending ED notices. It's the policy of '*Chanda do, Dhanda lo* (Give donations, take business)'. The BJP is misusing its position as the ruling party. That's the fundamental difference. It's illegal. That's how they collected such huge amounts. The BJP's means of fund collection is dacoity, we had to beg for funds.

**Q. Will Rahul Gandhi's two yatras help the Congress gain seats this election?**

There has been a massive impact. Rahul met millions of people from all walks of life during the yatras. He went to Manipur and stood by the people there. Modi has not set foot in Manipur till date while he had time to make dozens of trips abroad. The BJP-RSS only know how to set up the *nafrat ki dukan* (the shop of hatred). We go to people to talk about our ideology, to showcase our work, and not to make polarising speeches. The BJP-RSS is asking for a two-third majority because they want to frame a new Constitution. MPs and leaders of the party are already saying this. Is talking against the Constitution not anti-national? Modi deliberately asks his subordinates to make such statements so that he can assess the public sentiment.

**Q. The BJP keeps calling the Congress a party of dynasts, that they cannot look beyond the Gandhi family and that *parivarvaad* prevails.**

Could anyone force people to accept Indira Gandhi? Jawaharlal Nehru was not even alive when she became prime minister. Did he name her as his successor? Similarly, Rajiv Gandhi became prime minister after Indira had been assassinated. He was not named by her. It was the public mood. Since 1989, has any member of the Gandhi family taken any position in government? Sonia Gandhi sacrificed the opportunity to become prime minister in 2004 because she believed the country needed the service of an accomplished economist to pull it out of the financial crisis. She did not accept the PM's chair even when the party returned with a bigger mandate in 2009. After the 2002 Gujarat riots, Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee wanted to sack Modi as Gujarat chief minister. The then home minister L.K. Advani saved him. And today, see how Modi sidestepped Advani, just like the demon who, after being blessed with a boon by Lord Shiva, tried to kill his benefactor. The Gandhi family kept quiet even when Indira Gandhi was killed. They kept faith in the legal process. After Rajiv was assassinated, the Gandhi family did not spout venom about the killers. Priyanka Gandhi even went and met one of the accused in prison. It shows how much compassion the family has. In the BJP, Amit Shah punishes anyone who makes even a small mistake. In Uttar Pradesh, CM Yogi Adityanath uses the bulldozer.

**Q. Rahul Gandhi wanted all senior leaders to contest the Lok Sabha polls, but barring a few, most of them have declined. Even you are not contesting. Is this a sign that you have accepted defeat?**

If age had been on my side, I would have contested. About other leaders, we can't force anyone to contest polls. ■